

# How to write a REPORT

## What is a report?

A report is a clear, highly informative, well-structured and official text which analyses a certain issue for a specific person or group of people. Statistical data can be included in the task which the report writer then analyses. It sometimes includes interpretations and/or recommendations.

**Aim:** evaluate, explain, describe, analyse scientific research/developments/projects ,...,suggest, recommend

**Register:** Neutral, factual and formal

addressed to a superior, e.g. the manager / headmaster,... who has requested the report and wants to make decisions based on the information presented in the report

## **Structure and content:**

- Most include date/ from (writer) / to (recipient) / subject or topic  
Subject: must be clearly worded and refer to the topic of the report
- Introduction: States who the report is intended for (for whom?), the outline (topics and organisation) (what?) and aim/purpose of the report (why?) and how the writer has gathered the information (how?)
- Main part: Analysis of the topic (and data if provided) – facts, findings, data,...  
Use separate paragraphs for the different aspects.  
All paragraphs must have sub-headings.
- Conclusion: a brief summary;  
include a personal evaluation or recommendation if required

## **Style-** Typical linguistic features of ~~articles~~ **Reports**

- Accuracy (all facts need to be correct)  
Brevity (keep it short and to the point – no repetitions, unnecessary details)  
Clarity (logical and easy to understand, essential information)
- it is full of facts and factual language
- No personal or conversational language. Avoid the use of 'I' and 'you'. Use an impersonal style.
- No contractions (~~don't~~, ~~it's~~)
- Simple sentence structure (lots of short sentences, few subordinate clauses)
- Passive voice, reported speech (e.g. for information about what survey participants reported)
- A report is not a letter → no letter openings and endings

## **Sub-Headings**

Some commonly used sub-headings for the sections of the report (usually 5) are:

Introduction, Findings, Current Situation, Recent Trends, Survey Results, Advantages of ..., Disadvantages of ..., Suggestions, Conclusion and Recommendations, Future Measures, ...

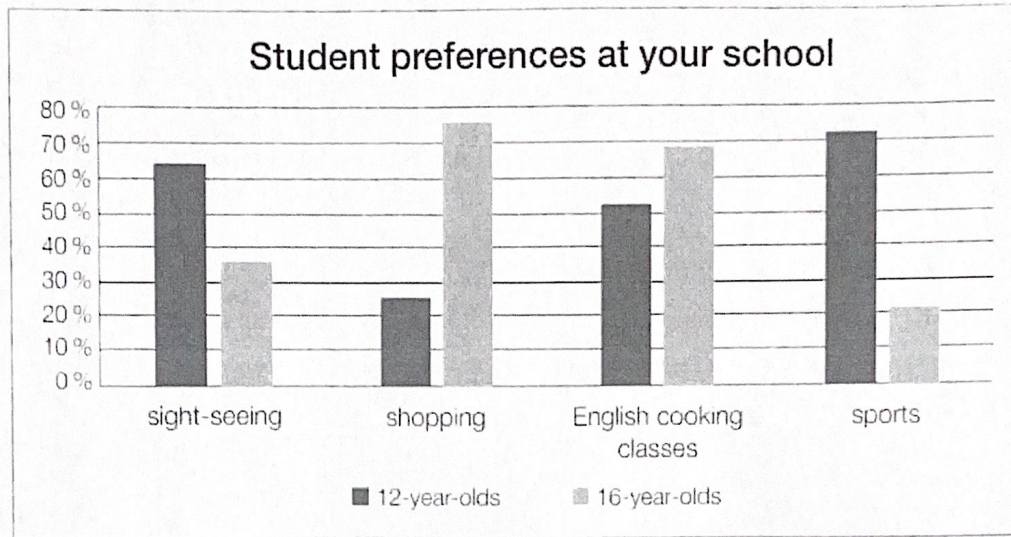
You can also use the bullet points as reference for your sub-headings

## Useful phrases

|                                                                  |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| introduction                                                     | <p>As requested, I have researched... / prepared a report on...</p> <p>The aim/purpose of this report is to inform/ point out/ compare the advantages and disadvantages of...</p> <p>This report is intended to provide information on...</p> <p>This report intends to/ aims at...</p> <p>This report will consider/examine/compare ...</p> <p>This report has been written to analyse...</p> <p>This report has been written at the request of/ on behalf of ...</p> <p>In order to prepare this report, Austrian A-level students were interviewed about...</p> <p>This report is based on a survey about...</p> <p>The source for this report is a recent survey on...</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| reporting results                                                | <p>According to the data ....</p> <p>The figures show that ...</p> <p>The pie chart/bar graph/line graph shows ...</p> <p>There is a slight/moderate/steady/significant increase/decrease in ...</p> <p>The majority of the interviewees felt/believed/complained.../ seem to feel that...</p> <p>Roughly/nearly/approximately/almost/about/around ... percent of ...</p> <p>The majority/a minority/ Almost 10%/More than 60 % ...</p> <p>A third of those questioned explained /thought/suggested that...</p> <p>They gave the following reasons/They made the following points:</p> <p>The majority of the interviewees seem to/tend to...</p> <p>The interviewees felt/mentioned that ... (+ reporting tenses)</p> <p>It seems/appears that...</p> <p>Interestingly/Surprisingly,... /It is surprising/astonishing that ...</p> <p>It remains unclear why .....</p> <p>Contrary to expectations, ....</p> <p>As might have been expected, ...</p> <p>The survey/study has shown that...</p> |
| Conclusion                                                       | <p>In conclusion, ...</p> <p>To summarise, ...</p> <p>To sum up, ...</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| Making recommendations<br>(use of personal pronoun "I" possible) | <p>I would therefore recommend ... (recommend +-ing)</p> <p>It would seem that ... (banning mobile phones) is the best idea.</p> <p>I would suggest ... (suggest +-ing)</p> <p>In view of this, I (would) recommend/ suggest that ...</p> <p>For this reason,... /Consequently, ...</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |

## Sample report – task and text

An international chain of language schools wants to update its programme. They have asked students around Europe for help to find out what kind of social activities are interesting for today's students. The writers of the most helpful reports will get a two-week stay at one of the language schools.



You have decided to send in a report based on this survey from your school.

In your **report** you should:

- contrast the preferences
- discuss reasons for the results
- make recommendations for additional activities

Divide your report into **sections** and give them **headings**. Write around **250 words**.

### (b) Sample report – HOW to do it

Date: September 19th

From: [jennifer.smith@hotmail.com](mailto:jennifer.smith@hotmail.com)

To: EY Language Schools

Subject: Report on which social activities are preferred by students.

■ Die ersten Zeilen entsprechen den formalen Anforderungen.

■ Der Titel spricht das Thema an.

#### Introduction

The purpose of this report is to summarise the findings of which social activities students prefer to do in their free time. The survey, for 12- and 16-year-olds, was carried out at my school.

■ Hier wird der Hintergrund der Umfrage erwähnt.

### The Preferences

As the results show, over 70% of the 16-year-olds say that their main social activity is shopping. This is followed by just under 70% for English cooking classes. In contrast, the majority of 12 year-olds, at 71%, are interested in doing sports, followed by sightseeing at just over 60%. In comparison, only about 21% of 16-year-olds preferred sports and only about 24% of 12-year-olds preferred shopping.

### Reasons for the Results

According to the results, 16-year-olds and 12 year-olds have very different interests. Most 12-year-olds are interested in sightseeing as they probably have not travelled as much as the 16-year-olds. For 16-year-olds, they prefer less physical activities and can see shopping as a social activity with friends rather than a chore with their parents.

### Recommendations

Some possible ideas for additional social activities would be to organise a language café with all the students or even a film night, where the film is shown in English without subtitles. Another idea would be to have a theatre production as students of all ages can be involved.

### Conclusion

Therefore, based on the results of the survey, it would be best if the language school's programme offered a variety of social activities, some specifically for the younger or older students and some which all age groups can do together.

#### ■ 1<sup>st</sup> bullet point

- Die Unterschiede, die sich aus der Umfrage ergeben haben, werden dargelegt.

#### ■ 2<sup>nd</sup> bullet point

- Hier führt die Autorin mögliche Gründe für die unterschiedlichen Ergebnisse der Umfrage an.

#### ■ 3<sup>rd</sup> bullet point

- Hier macht die Verfasserin Vorschläge über zusätzliche Aktivitäten der Sprachschule

- Im letzten Absatz zieht die Autorin ihren Schluss aus dem Ergebnis der Umfrage.

- passende Länge

Source: "Durchstarten zur Zentralmatura Englisch. Aufgaben September 2017". Veritas.  
[https://www.veritas.at/vproduct/download/download/sku/OM\\_39605\\_9](https://www.veritas.at/vproduct/download/download/sku/OM_39605_9)

Find another sample task in your Companion book on page 64-65